

As we walked, taking the way he had indicated, I recounted all I knew. Poirot listened attentively.

'The dagger was in the wound, you say? That is curious. You are sure it was the same one?'

'Absolutely certain. That's what make it so impossible.'

'Nothing is impossible. There may have been two daggers.'

I raised my eyebrows.

'Surely that is in the highest degree unlikely? It would be a most extraordinary coincidence.'

'You speak as usual, without reflection, Hastings. In some cases two identical weapons *would* be highly improbable. But not here. This particular weapon was a war souvenir which was made to Jack Renauld's orders. It is really highly unlikely, when you come to think of it, that he should have had only one made. Very probably he would have another for his own use.'

'But nobody has mentioned such a thing,' I objected.

A hint of the lecturer crept into Poirot's tone. 'My friend, in working upon a case, one does not take into account only the things that are "mentioned." There is no reason to mention many things which may be important. Equally, there is often an excellent reason for *not* mentioning them. You can take your choice of the two motives.'

I was silent, impressed in spite of myself. Another few minutes brought us to the famous shed. We found all our friends there and, after an interchange of polite amenities, Poirot began his task.

Having watched Giraud at work, I was keenly interested. Poirot bestowed but a cursory glance on the surroundings. The only thing he examined was the ragged coat and trousers by the door. A disdainful smile rose to Giraud's lips, and, as though noting it, Poirot flung the bundle down again.

'Old clothes of the gardener's?' he queried.

'Exactly,' said Giraud.

Poirot knelt down by the body. His fingers were rapid but methodical. He examined the texture of the clothes, and satisfied himself that there were no marks on them. The boots he subjected to special care, also the dirty and broken finger-nails. Whilst examining the latter he threw a quick question at Giraud.

'You saw these?'

'Yes, I saw them,' replied the other. His face remained inscrutable. Suddenly Poirot stiffened.

'Dr Durand!'

'Yes?' The doctor came forward.

'There is foam on the lips. You observed it?'

'I didn't notice it, I must admit.'

'But you observe it now?'

'Oh, certainly.'

Poirot again shot a question at Giraud.

'You noticed it without doubt?'

The other did not reply. Poirot proceeded. The dagger had been withdrawn from the wound. It reposed in a glass jar by the side of the body. Poirot examined it, then he studied the wound closely. When he looked up, his eyes were excited, and shone with the green light I knew so well.

'It is a strange wound, this! It has not bled. There is no stain on the clothes. The blade of the dagger is slightly discoloured, that is all. What do you think, M. le docteur?'

'I can only say that it is most abnormal.'

'It is not abnormal at all. It is most simple. The man was stabbed *after he was dead*.' And, stilling the clamour of voices that arose with a wave of his hand, Poirot turned to Giraud and added, 'M. Giraud agrees with me, do you not, monsieur?'

Whatever Giraud's real belief, he accepted the position without moving a muscle. Calmly and almost scornfully he replied:

'Certainly I agree.'

The murmur of surprise and interest broke out again.

'But what an ideal!' cried M. Hauter. 'To stab a man after he is dead! Barbaric! Unheard of! Some unappeasable hate, perhaps.'

'No, M. le juge,' said Poirot. 'I should fancy it was done quite cold-bloodedly—to create an impression.'

'What impression?'

'The impression it nearly did create,' returned Poirot oracularly.

M. Bex had been thinking.

'How, then, was the man killed?'

‘He was not killed. He died. He died, M. le juge, if I am not much mistaken, of an epileptic fit!’

This statement of Poirot’s again aroused considerable excitement. Dr Durand knelt down again, and made a searching examination. At last he rose to his feet.

‘Well, M. le docteur?’

‘M. Poirot, I am inclined to believe that you are correct in your assertion. I was misled to begin with. The incontrovertible fact that the man had been stabbed distracted my attention from any other indications.’

Poirot was the hero of the hour. The examining magistrate was profuse in compliments. Poirot responded gracefully, and then excused himself on the pretext that neither he nor I had yet lunched, and that he wished to repair the ravages of the journey. As we were about to leave the shed, Giraud approached us.

‘One more thing, M. Poirot,’ he said, in his suave mocking voice. ‘We found this coiled round the handle of the dagger. A woman’s hair.’

‘Ah!’ said Poirot. ‘A woman’s hair? What woman’s, I wonder?’

‘I wonder also,’ said Giraud. Then, with a bow, he left us.

‘He was insistent, the good Giraud,’ said Poirot thoughtfully, as we walked towards the hotel. ‘I wonder in what direction he hopes to mislead me? A woman’s hair—h’m!’

We lunched heartily, but I found Poirot somewhat distraught and inattentive. Afterwards we went up to our sitting-room and there I begged him to tell me something of his mysterious journey to Paris.

‘Willingly, my friend. I went to Paris to find *this*.’

He took from his pocket a small faded newspaper cutting. It was the reproduction of a woman’s photograph. He handed it to me. I uttered an exclamation.

‘You recognize it, my friend?’

I nodded. Although the photo obviously dated from very many years back, and the hair was dressed in a different style, the likeness was unmistakable.

‘Madame Daubreuil!’ I exclaimed.

Poirot shook his head with a smile.

‘Not quite correct, my friend. She did not call herself by that name in those days. That is a picture of the notorious Madame Beroldy!’

I have frequently been disappointed when fancying that I was giving news of importance to my friend. Either he has known it already or he has dismissed it as irrelevant to the main issue—and in the latter case events have usually proved him justified. But this time I could not complain of missing my effect. Never have I seen a man so flabbergasted. His jaw dropped. All the jauntiness went out of his bearing. He stared at me open-mouthed.

‘What is that you say? Another murder? Ah, then, I am all wrong. I have failed. Giraud may mock himself at me—he will have reason!’

‘You did not expect it, then?’

‘I? Not the least in the world. It demolishes my theory—it ruins everything—it—ah, no!’ He stopped dead, thumping himself on the chest. ‘It is impossible. I *cannot* be wrong! The facts, taken methodically and in their proper order admit of only one explanation. I must be right! I *am* right!’

‘But then—’

He interrupted me.

‘Wait, my friend. I must be right, therefore this new murder is impossible unless—unless—oh, wait, I implore you. Say no word—’

He was silent for a moment or two, then, resuming his normal manner, he said in a quiet assured voice: ‘The victim is a man of middle-age. His body was found in the locked shed near the scene of the crime and had been dead at least forty-eight hours. And it is most probable that he was stabbed in a similar manner to M. Renaud, though not necessarily in the back.’

It was my turn to gape—and gape I did. In all my knowledge of Poirot he had never done anything so amazing as this. And, almost inevitably, a doubt crossed my mind.

‘Poirot,’ I cried, ‘you’re pulling my leg. You’ve heard all about it already.’

He turned his earnest gaze upon me reproachfully.

‘Would I do such a thing? I assure you that I have heard nothing whatsoever.

Did you not observe the shock your news was to me?’

‘But how on earth could you know all that?’

‘I was right then? But I knew it. The little grey cells, my friend, the little grey cells! They told me. Thus, and in no other way, could there have been a second death. Now tell me all. If we go round to the left here, we can take a short cut across the golf links which will bring us to the back of the Villa Geneviève much more quickly.’

have noticed two foreigners—he was sure of it. Only about twenty people had left by the train, and he could not have failed to observe them.

I do not know what put the idea into my head—possibly it was the deep anxiety underlying Marthe Daubreuil's tones—but I asked suddenly:

'Young M. Renaud—he did not leave by that train, did he?'

'Ah, no, monsieur. To arrive and start off again within half an hour, it would not be amusing, that!'

I stared at the man, the significance of his words almost escaping me. Then I saw...

'You mean,' I said, my heart beating a little, 'that M. Jack Renaud arrived at Merlinville that evening?'

'But yes, monsieur. By the last train arriving the other way, the 11:40.'

My brain whirled. That, then, was the reason of Marthe's poignant anxiety. Jack Renaud had been in Merlinville on the night of the crime! But why had he not said so? Why, on the contrary, had he led us to believe that he had remained in Cherbourg? Remembering his frank boyish countenance, I could hardly bring myself to believe that he had any connection with the crime. Yet why this silence on his part about so vital a matter? One thing was certain, Marthe had known all along. Hence her anxiety, and her eager questioning of Poirot to know whether any one were suspected.

My cogitations were interrupted by the arrival of the train, and in another moment I was greeting Poirot. The little man was radiant. He beamed and vociferated and, forgetting my English reluctance, embraced me warmly on the platform.

'*Mon cher ami*, I have succeeded—but succeeded to a marvel!'

'Indeed? I'm delighted to hear it. Have you heard the latest here?'

'How would you that I should hear anything? There have been some developments, eh? The brave Giraud, he has made an arrest? Or even arrests perhaps? Ah, but I will make him look foolish, that one! But where are you taking me, my friend? Do we not go to the hotel? It is necessary that I attend to my moustaches—they are deplorably limp from the heat of travelling. Also, without doubt, there is dust on my coat. And my tie, that I must rearrange.'

I cut short his remonstrances.

'My dear Poirot—never mind all that. We must go to the Villa at once. *There has been another murder!*'

Madame Beroldy! In a flash the whole thing came back to me. The murder trial that had evoked such world-wide interest.

The Beroldy Case.

Chapter 15

A Photograph

THE doctor's words were so surprising that we were all momentarily taken aback. Here was a man stabbed with a dagger which we knew to have been stolen only twenty-four hours previously, and yet Dr Durand asserted positively that he had been dead at least forty-eight hours! The whole thing was fantastic to the last extreme.

We were still recovering from the surprise of the doctor's announcement, when a telegram was brought to me. It had been sent up from the hotel to the Villa. I tore it open. It was from Poirot, and announced his return by the train arriving at Merlenville at 12:28.

I looked at my watch and saw that I had just time to get comfortably to the station and meet him there. I felt that it was of the utmost importance that he should know at once of the new and startling developments in the case.

Evidently, I reflected, Poirot had had no difficulty in finding what he wanted in Paris. The quickness of his return proved that. Very few hours had sufficed. I wondered how he would take the exciting news I had to impart.

The train was some minutes late, and I strolled aimlessly up and down the platform, until it occurred to me that I might pass the time by asking a few questions as to who had left Merlenville by the last train on the evening of the tragedy.

I approached the chief porter, an intelligent looking man, and had little difficulty in persuading him to enter upon the subject. It was a disgrace to the Police, he hotly affirmed, that such brigands of assassins should be allowed to go about unpunished. I hinted that there was some possibility they might have left by the midnight train, but he negatived the idea decidedly. He would

The doctor knelt down by the dead man, and Giraud turned to the examining magistrate.

‘A pretty little problem, is it not? But I shall solve it.’

‘And so no one can identify him,’ mused the magistrate. ‘Could it possibly be one of the assassins? They may have fallen out among themselves.’

Giraud shook his head.

‘The man is a Frenchman—I would take my oath of that—’

But at that moment they were interrupted by the doctor who was sitting back on his heels with a perplexed expression.

‘You say he was killed yesterday morning?’

‘I fix it by the theft of the dagger,’ explained Giraud. ‘He may, of course, have been killed later in the day.’

‘Later in the day? Fiddlesticks! This man has been dead at least forty-eight hours, and probably longer.’

We stared at each other in blank amazement.

Chapter 16

The Beroldy Case



OME twenty years or so before the opening of the present story, Monsieur Arnold Beroldy, a native of Lyons, arrived in Paris accompanied by his pretty wife and their little daughter, a mere babe. Monsieur Beroldy was a junior partner in a firm of wine merchants, a stout middle-aged man, fond of the good things of life, devoted to his charming wife, and altogether unremarkable in every way. The firm in which Monsieur Beroldy was a partner was a small one, and although doing well, it did not yield a large income to the junior partner. The Beroldys had a small apartment and lived in a very modest fashion to begin with.

But unremarkable though Monsieur Beroldy might be, his wife was plentifully gilded with the brush of Romance. Young and good looking, and gifted withal with a singular charm of manner, Madame Beroldy at once created a stir in the quarter, especially when it began to be whispered that some interesting mystery surrounded her birth. It was rumoured that she was the illegitimate daughter of a Russian Grand Duke. Others asserted that it was an Austrian Archduke, and that the union was legal, though morganatic. But all stories agreed upon one point, that Jeanne Beroldy was the centre of an interesting mystery. Questioned by the curious, Madame Beroldy did not deny these rumours. On the other hand she let it be clearly understood that, though her ‘lips’ were ‘sealed,’ all these stories had a foundation in fact. To intimate friends she unburdened herself further, spoke of political intrigues, of ‘papers,’ of obscure dangers that threatened her. There was also much talk of Crown jewels that were to be sold secretly, with herself acting as the go-between.

Amongst the friends and acquaintances of the Beroldys was a young lawyer, Georges Conneau. It was soon evident that the fascinating Jeanne had

completely enslaved his heart. Madame Beroldy encouraged the young man in a discreet fashion, but being always careful to affirm her complete devotion to her middle-aged husband. Nevertheless, many spiteful persons did not hesitate to declare that young Conneau was her lover—and not the only one!

When the Beroldys had been in Paris about three months, another personage came upon the scene. This was Mr Hiram P. Trapp, a native of the United States, and extremely wealthy. Introduced to the charming and mysterious Madame Beroldy, he fell a prompt victim to her fascinations. His admiration was obvious, though strictly respectful.

About this time, Madame Beroldy became more outspoken in her confidences. To several friends, she declared herself greatly worried on her husband's behalf. She explained that he had been drawn into several schemes of a political nature, and also referred to some important papers that had been entrusted to him for safekeeping and which concerned a 'secret' of far reaching European importance. They had been entrusted to his custody to throw pursuers off the track, but Madame Beroldy was nervous, having recognized several important members of the Revolutionary Circle in Paris.

On the 28th day of November, the blow fell. The woman who came daily to clean and cook for the Beroldys was surprised to find the door of the apartment standing wide open. Hearing faint moans issuing from the bedroom, she went in. A terrible sight met her eyes. Madame Beroldy lay on the floor, bound hand and foot, uttering feeble moans, having managed to free her mouth from a gag. On the bed was Monsieur Beroldy, lying in a pool of blood, with a knife driven through his heart.

Madame Beroldy's story was clear enough. Suddenly awakened from sleep, she had discerned two masked men bending over her. Stifling her cries, they had bound and gagged her. They had then demanded of Monsieur Beroldy the famous 'secret.'

But the intrepid wine merchant refused point-blank to accede to their request. Angered by his refusal, one of the men incontinently stabbed him through the heart. With the dead man's keys, they had opened the safe in the corner, and had carried away with them a mass of papers. Both men were heavily bearded, and had worn masks, but Madame Beroldy declared positively that they were Russians.

'I do not know him.'

It seemed impossible to doubt her, the words came so naturally. Giraud dismissed her with a nod of the head. 'You are letting her go?' I asked in a low voice. 'Is that wise? Surely that black hair is from her head.'

'I do not need reaching my business,' said Giraud dryly. 'She is under surveillance. I have no wish to arrest her as yet.'

Then, frowning, he gazed down at the body.

'Should you say that was a Spanish type at all?' he asked suddenly.

I considered the face carefully.

'No,' I said at last. 'I should put him down as a Frenchman most decidedly.'

Giraud gave a grunt of dissatisfaction.

'Same here.'

He stood there for a moment, then with an imperative gesture he waved me aside, and once more, on hands and knees, he continued his search of the floor of the shed. He was marvellous. Nothing escaped him. Inch by inch he went over the floor, turning over pots, examining old sacks. He pounced on a bundle by the door, but it proved to be only a ragged coat and trousers, and he flung it down again with a snarl. Two pairs of old gloves interested him, but in the end he shook his head and laid them aside. Then he went back to the pots, methodically turning them over one by one. In the end, he rose to his feet, and shook his head thoughtfully. He seemed baffled and perplexed. I think he had forgotten my presence.

But, at that moment, a stir and bustle was heard outside, and our old friend, the examining magistrate, accompanied by his clerk and M. Bex, with the doctor behind him, came bustling in.

'But this is extraordinary, Mr Giraud,' cried M. Hautet. 'Another crime! Ah, we have not got to the bottom of this case. There is some deep mystery here. But who is the victim this time?'

'That is just what nobody can tell us, M. le juge. He has not been identified.'

'Where is the body?,' asked the doctor.

Giraud moved aside a little.

'There in the corner. He has been stabbed to the heart, as you see. And with the dagger that was stolen yesterday morning. I fancy that the murder followed hard upon the theft—but that is for you to say. You can handle the dagger freely—there are no finger-prints on it.'

‘Quite sure.’

‘You do not recognize in him one of your assailants, for instance?’

‘No,’ she seemed to hesitate, as though struck by the idea. ‘No, I do not think so. Of course they wore beards—false ones the examining magistrate thought, but still—no.’ Now she seemed to make her mind up definitely. ‘I am sure neither of the two was this man.’

‘Very well, madame. That is all, then.’

She stepped out with head erect, the sun flashing on the silver threads in her hair. Jack Renaud succeeded her. He, too, failed to identify the man, in a completely natural manner.

Giraud merely grunted. Whether he was pleased or chagrined I could not tell. He merely called to Marchaud:

‘You have got the other there?’

‘Yes, monsieur.’

‘Bring her in then.’

‘The other’ was Madame Daubreuil. She came indignantly, protesting with vehemence.

‘I object, monsieur! This is an outrage! What have I to do with all this?’

‘Madame,’ said Giraud brutally, ‘I am investigating not one murder, but two murders! For all I know you may have committed them both.’

‘How dare you?’ she cried. ‘How dare you insult me by such a wild accusation! It is infamous.’

‘Infamous, is it? What about this?’ Stooping, he again detached the hair, and held it up. ‘Do you see this, madame?’ He advanced towards her. ‘You permit that I see whether it matches?’

With a cry she started backwards, white to the lips.

‘It is false—I swear it. I know nothing of the crime—of either crime. Any one who says I do lies! Ah! *mon Dieu*, what shall I do?’

‘Calm yourself, madame,’ said Giraud coldly. ‘No one has accused you as yet. But you will do well to answer my questions without more ado.’

‘Anything you wish, monsieur.’

‘Look at the dead man. Have you ever seen him before?’

Drawing nearer, a little of the colour creeping back to her face, Madame Daubreuil looked down at the victim with a certain amount of interest and curiosity. Then she shook her head.

The affair created an immense sensation. It was referred to variously as ‘the Nihilist Atrocity,’ ‘Revolutionaries in Paris,’ and the ‘Russian Mystery.’ Time went on, and the mysterious bearded men were never traced. And then, just as public interest was beginning to die down, a startling development occurred. Madame Beroldy was arrested and charged with the murder of her husband.

The trial, when it came on, aroused widespread interest. The youth and beauty of the accused, and her mysterious history, were sufficient to make of it a *cause célèbre*. People ranged themselves wildly for or against the prisoner. But her partisans received several severe checks to their enthusiasm. The romantic past of Madame Beroldy, her royal blood, and the mysterious intrigues in which she had her being were shown to be mere fantasies of the imagination.

It was proved beyond doubt that Jeanne Beroldy’s parents were a highly respectable and prosaic couple, fruit merchants, who lived on the outskirts of Lyons. The Russian Grand Duke, the court intrigues, and the political schemes—all the stories current were traced back to—the lady herself! From her brain had emanated these ingenious myths, and she was proved to have raised a considerable sum of money from various credulous persons by her fiction of the ‘Crown jewels’—the jewels in question being found to be mere paste imitations. Remorselessly the whole story of her life was laid bare. The motive for the murder was found in Mr Hiram P. Trapp. Mr Trapp did his best, but relentlessly and agilely cross-questioned he was forced to admit that he loved the lady, and that, had she been free, he would have asked her to be his wife. The fact that the relations between them were admittedly platonic strengthened the case against the accused. Debarred from becoming his mistress by the simple honourable nature of the man, Jeanne Beroldy had conceived the monstrous project of ridding herself of her elderly undistinguished husband, and becoming the wife of the rich American.

Throughout, Madame Beroldy confronted her accusers with complete sang froid and self possession. Her story never varied. She continued to declare strenuously that she was of royal birth, and that she had been substituted for the daughter of the fruit seller at an early age. Absurd and completely unsubstantiated as these statements were, a great number of people believed implicitly in their truth.

But the prosecution was implacable. It denounced the masked ‘Russians’ as a myth, and asserted that the crime had been committed by Madame Beroldy

and her lover, Georges Conneau. A warrant was issued for the arrest of the latter, but he had wisely disappeared. Evidence showed that the bonds which secured Madame Beroldy were so loose that she could easily have freed herself.

And then, towards the close of the trial, a letter, posted in Paris, was sent to the Public Prosecutor. It was from Georges Conneau and, without revealing his whereabouts, it contained a full confession of the crime. He declared that he had indeed struck the fatal blow at Madame Beroldy's instigation. The crime had been planned between them. Believing that her husband ill-treated her, and maddened by his own passion for her, a passion which he believed her to return, he had planned the crime and struck the fatal blow that should free the woman he loved from a hateful bondage. Now, for the first time, he learnt of Mr Hiram P. Trapp, and realized that the woman he loved had betrayed him! Not for his sake did she wish to be free—but in order to marry the wealthy American. She had used him as a cat's-paw, and now, in his jealous rage, he turned and denounced her, declaring that throughout he had acted at her instigation.

And then Madame Beroldy proved herself the remarkable woman she undoubtedly was. Without hesitation, she dropped her previous defence, and admitted that the 'Russians' were a pure invention on her part. The real murderer was Georges Conneau. Maddened by passion, he had committed the crime, vowing that if she did not keep silence he would enact a terrible vengeance from her. Terrified by his threats, she had consented—also fearing it likely that if she told the truth she might be accused of conniving at the crime. But she had steadfastly refused to have anything more to do with her husband's murderer, and it was in revenge for this attitude on her part that he had written this letter accusing her. She swore solemnly that she had had nothing to do with the planning of the crime, that she had awoken on that memorable night to find Georges Conneau standing over her, the blood-stained knife in his hand.

It was a touch and go affair. Madame Beroldy's story was hardly credible. But this woman, whose fairy tales of royal intrigues had been so easily accepted, had the supreme art of making herself believed. Her address to the jury was a masterpiece. The tears streaming down her face, she spoke of her child, of her woman's honour—of her desire to keep her reputation untarnished for the child's sake. She admitted that, Georges Conneau having been her lover,

'They are not the hands of a gentleman,' he said, answering my look. 'On the contrary his clothes are those of a well-to-do man. That is curious, is it not?'

'Very curious,' I agreed.

'And none of his clothing is marked. What do we learn from that? This man was trying to pass himself off as other than he was. He was masquerading. Why? Did he fear something? Was he trying to escape by disguising himself? As yet we do not know, but one thing we do know—he was as anxious to conceal his identity as we are to discover it.'

He looked down at the body again.

'As before there are no finger-prints on the handle of the dagger. The murderer again wore gloves.'

'You think, then, that the murderer was the same in both cases?' I asked eagerly.

Giraud became inscrutable.

'Never mind what I think. We shall see. Marchaud!'

The *sergent de ville* appeared at the doorway.

'Monsieur?'

'Why is Madame Renaud not here? I sent for her a quarter of an hour ago?'

'She is coming up the path now, monsieur, and her son with her.'

'Good. I only want one at a time, though.'

Marchaud saluted and disappeared again. A moment later he reappeared with Mrs Renaud.

'Here is Madame.'

Giraud came forward with a curt bow.

'This way, madame.' He led her across, and then, standing suddenly aside.

'Here is the man. Do you know him?'

And as he spoke, his eyes, gimlet-like, bored into her face, seeking to read her mind, noting every indication of her manner.

But Mrs Renaud remained perfectly calm—too calm, I felt. She looked down at the corpse almost without interest, certainly without any sign of agitation or recognition.

'No,' she said. 'I have never seen him in my life. He is quite a stranger to me.'

'You are sure?'